New Commons Submission Analysis

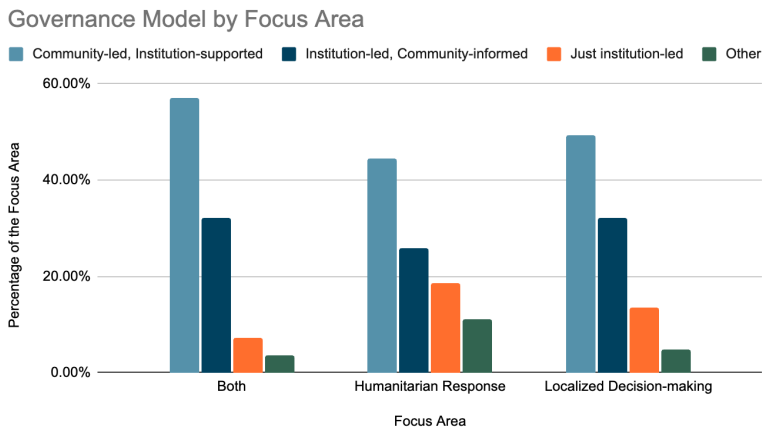
One Page Overview

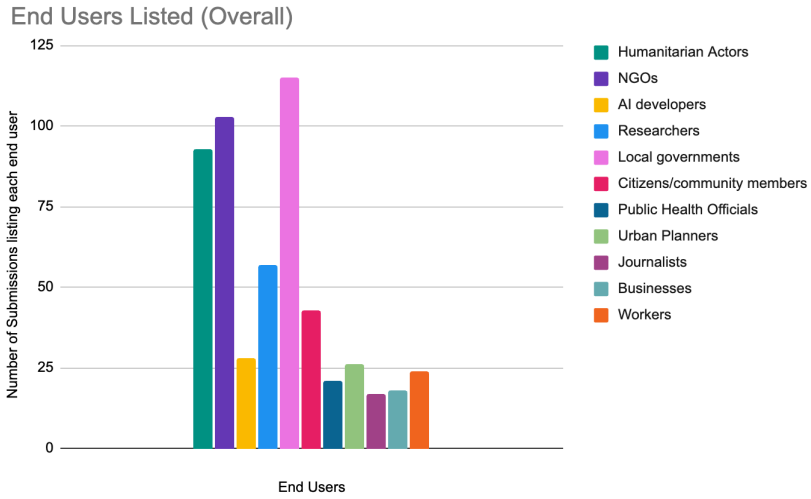
Big Picture:

- **50%** of submissions are Community-led, Institution-supported
- **30%** of submissions are Institution-led, Community-informed
- **7%** of submissions have a unique hybrid structure
- **13%** of submissions are just institution-led

Fast Facts:

- **55%** of submissions described a **multi-stakeholder council or board**
- **66%** of submissions described **managing technical infrastructure in-house**, as opposed to working with a partner institution or technical partner
- **14** submissions **(nearly 10%)** involve **youth** in their governance structure, in consultative roles or on multi-stakeholder boards. All but one of these 14 submissions are in the "Community-led, institution-supported" category





A cleaned version of the dataset can be found here, with tags for each entry to allow for sorting by end user, focus area, country, region, etc.
(Here's my very messy working document with some other notes, but harder to navigate)

Detailed Analysis

Who makes strategic decisions? Who handles technical infrastructure and day-to-day operations? How should the data commons integrate input from experts, data providers, data users, and data subjects (those whom the data is about)? How is feedback collected?

I made sense of common governance components in the following way. Even with this breakdown, there is still a ton of nuance, overlap, outliers, and differences in vocabulary. Details and submission examples for each item below are at the bottom of this document.

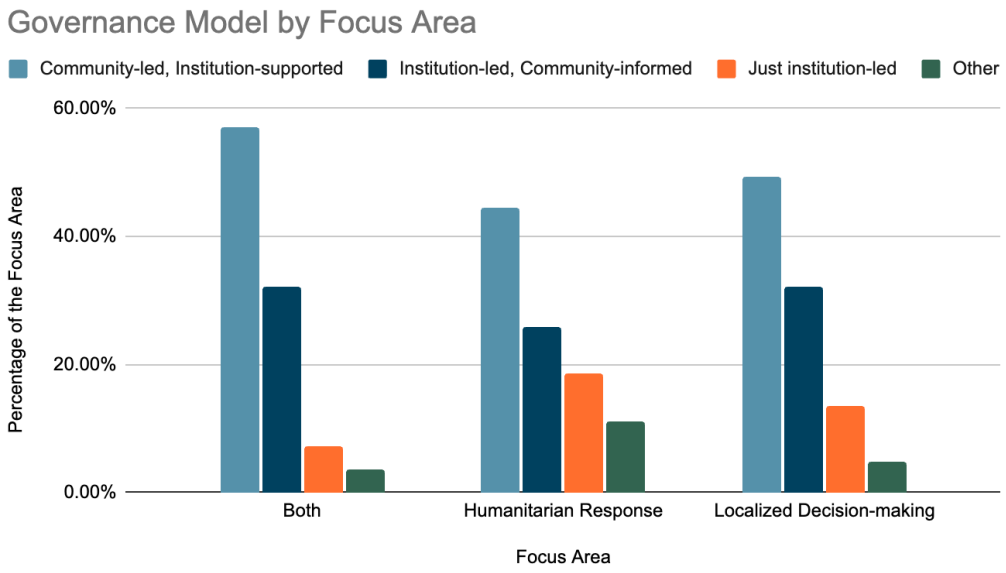
1. Strategic Governing Structures
    a. Multi-stakeholder governance boards
    b. Internal Team with advisory body
    c. Localized hubs
    d. Institutional anchoring bodies / Multi-institutional leadership
2. Operational Management Entities
    a. In-house day to day technical management
    b. Technical partner or host institution
    c. Other
3. Ethics and Advisory Bodies
    a. Advisory Panels or Councils
    b. Ethics Review Councils
    c. Technical Advisory Councils
    d. Institutional Oversight
4. Community Feedback and Participation
    a. Testing & Ideation Groups
    b. Public Community Assemblies
    c. Community Trainings
    d. Real-time feedback mechanisms
    e. Surveys
    f. Audits and Reporting

Although each entry's governance can be described by some combination of the above features, most fell into two big-picture categories:

- **50% Community-led, Institution-supported:** Data commons that are strategically managed and advised by members of the community, outside experts, and users. The institution or organization is responsible for day-to-day operations and implementation, or collaborates with a technical partner. (55.pdf for example)

- **30% Institution-led, Community-informed:** Data commons that are under the strategic direction of the operating organization, with mechanisms for community input in place such as advisory councils, public town halls, working groups, or stakeholder consultation. (112.pdf or 114.pdf for example)

Some proposals fall into neither category, with about **13%** of submissions not describing much community involvement at all, and several others (**7%**) operating under unique hybrid structures.



I used a broad interpretation of "community," including end users, data providers, data subjects, etc.

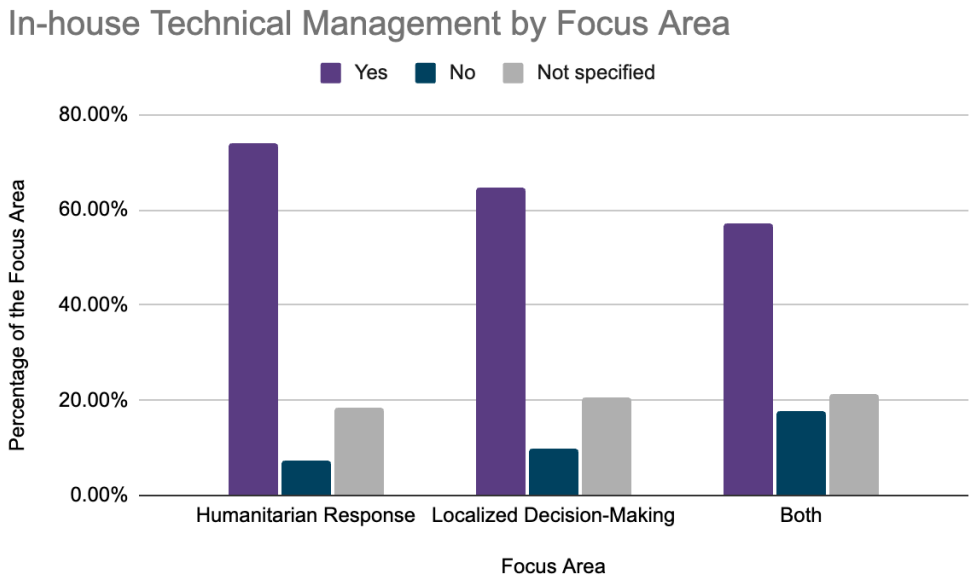
The most common governing component was a **multi-stakeholder board**, present in about 55% of submissions. In the **community-led, institution-supported model**, the multi-stakeholder board often serves as the decision-making entity, with voting mechanisms and greater authority over data policy, usage, and strategy. Under the **institution-led, community-informed model**, a multi-stakeholder council is one option for community input and oversight, along with advisory councils, local data stewardship structures, or other participatory processes.

19% of submissions included a structure of **localized hubs**: local nodes, councils, or data stewards from a regional, community, or participating organization level. The specifics vary widely. For example, 130.pdf The Climate Data and Adaptation Hub, describes 11 municipalities contributing data, each supported by a local steering committee to

prioritize needs and validate outputs. For reference, in this case, governance is also shared with regional multi-stakeholder groups and NGO partners in different "governance layers." Another example, 145.pdf The Global Freedom of Information Data Commons describes regional coordination councils that manage country-specific partnerships, data collection protocols, and local adaption requirements. This submission also describes a data commons governing board, technical advisory committees, and an ethics and public interest panel.

Technical Management

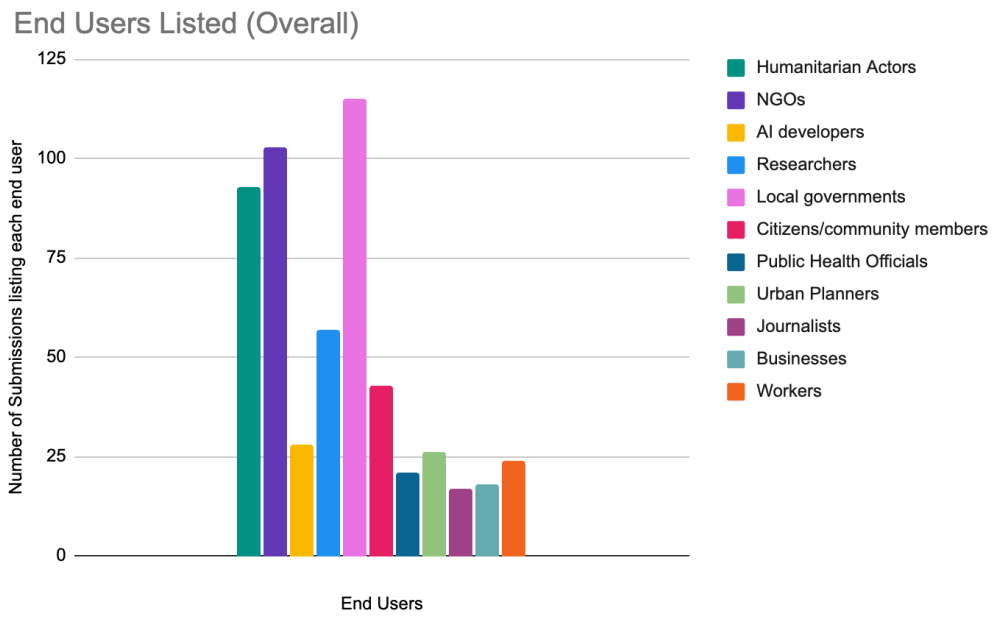
The breakdown is as follows. Interestingly, the submissions with a focus area of both humanitarian response and localized decision-making had a slightly higher percentage of submissions that outsource technical management.



End Users

End users, as expected, often depended on the focus area (humanitarian response vs local decision-making). Humanitarian response has the most humanitarian actors as end users. Local decision-making has more local governments, public health officials, urban planners. Across both focus areas, **13** submissions included workers as end users, which could mean farmers, fishermen, informal workers, etc.

17 submissions listed journalists as end users, often as a way of connecting the data-driven insights to the general public through evidence-based reporting.



All submissions listed more than one end user group and are reflected in multiple categories above.
(If you're curious, 3 more graphs showing the breakdown by focus area are at the bottom of the document)

Data Access
Any specified details about data access are pulled out for each submission here.
Common methods:

- Completely open access for all, either with or without an account
- Tiered access based on **data sensitivity** (for example, see 78.pdf : open access for non-sensitive datasets and controlled access for licensed or sensitive datasets)
- Tiered access based on **user role** (for example, see 48.pdf : full datasets for researchers, summary dashboards for community use)
- Various **tiered payment systems** (for example, see 162.pdf : public dashboards and open data access remains free, while services like high-volume API access, customized analytics, or institutional integrations are available for paying users)

Licenses referenced (roughly in order of highest to lowest frequency of occurrence):

- Creative Commons: Reusers can distribute, remix, adapt and build upon the material in any medium or format
    - CC-BY / Creative Commons Attribution: Credit must be given to the creator
    - CC-BY-NC: Credit must be given to the creator, and only noncommercial uses of the work are permitted

    - CC BY-SA: Credit must be given to the creator, and adaptations must be shared under the same terms
- Open Data Commons: Users can freely share, modify, and use data
- MIT: A software license allowing use, modification, and distribution
- Nwulite Obodo Open Data License: A license for sharing African datasets in ways that are open for all and yet equitable for the source community (e.g., differentiating between contexts of users)

Data Accessibility:
Several proposals addressed accessibility obstacles by proposing multilingual support or simplified visual interfaces.

Innovative Approaches or Features

- 27.pdf proposes a Decentralized Autonomous Organization (DAO) structure, where policies are submitted, debated, and voted on through a blockchain-based platform for stakeholders.
- 50.pdf proposes a Model Accountability Register, allowing any institution developing AI systems trained on the data commons to disclose performance, biases, and system limitations
- 55.pdf proposes mechanisms like data dividends or community recognition credits to reward people who contribute valuable insight or knowledge to the commons
- 57.pdf proposes risk scoring methodologies for algorithms
- 121.pdf proposes micro-compensation (e.g., $1 per use) for contributions
- 123.pdf proposes hiring dedicated community liaisons to get input from community members
- 130.pdf proposes modular replication toolkits of all governance and process assets - diagnostic tools, metadata pipelines, dashboard templates, and access protocols, including implementation guides. It also proposes a cohort-based onboarding program for municipal partners.
- 149.pdf proposes data validation by community moderators (e.g., 100+ parents confirming “$50/session = Low-Cost”). This submission also proposes granular opt-ins for consent (e.g., “Anonymize my child’s IEP for policy research only”). This submission also proposes “Bias Bounties”, monetary rewards for validated user flags.
- 170.pdf proposes a Commons-Learning-Network for sharing case studies, co-developing training datasets, and contributing to model adaptation

Breakdown of Governance Components

Strategic Governing Structures		
Structure	**Details**	**Example**
Multi-Stakeholder Governance Boards	About 55% of submissions described a form of multi-stakeholder board composed of several of the following possible stakeholder groups: Community members and leaders, end users, data providers, representatives from local governments or humanitarian agencies, technical and subject experts, representatives from partner NGOs or academic institutions, legal experts, and more. These range from 6-member boards to large voting bodies of 50+ people. In many cases, the multi-stakeholder board acts as a **steering committee**, responsible for voting on all major strategic decisions and policy about the data commons. The level of authority and responsibility varies.	108.pdf (WaterGuard): This proposal outlines a multi-stakeholder commons governance board that meets quarterly and votes on access tiers, partnerships, and data use. It includes: Community representatives (30%), Academic & Technical partners (25%), Public sector representatives (20%), NGOs & Civil Society representatives (15%), and the WaterGuard Core Team (10%). The Core Team, responsible for operations, has limited voting rights to prevent conflict of interest.
Internal Team with Advisory Body	About 30% of submissions described a model where the host organization makes strategic decisions with an advisory body playing a consultative or oversight-based role. This can be a panel of experts, a group of partner organizations, or a multi-stakeholder council that is not the primary decision-making entity. (See ethics and advisory mechanisms)	114.pdf (Certi Amazonia): This proposal describes a team within the nonprofit that will manage the strategic decisions as well as the sustained operation of the commons. An advisory board of representatives from environmental organizations, academic institutions, local communities, and government agencies provides guidance and ensures public-interest alignment.
Localized Hubs	19% of submissions included local nodes, councils, or data stewards from a regional, community, or participating organization level. This is most common when the structure of data	137.pdf (Technology Integrity Council): Each participating city or region has a governance node of a municipal liaison or public agency representative, a local

	contribution or use is based on specific participating organizations or municipalities, in which case this structure allows for input on that level.	civil society or NGO partner, and a legal or technology advisor. They adapt the overarching Commons Charter to fit local laws, cultural norms, and needs.
Institutional Anchoring Bodies /Multi-institutional Leadership	Around 20% of submissions involved a specific major partnership or co-leadership structure with other institution(s). Multi-institutional leadership captures a range of approaches. Some proposals outlined a decision-making board made up of a set group of partner organizations. Others defined organization-specific roles, such as one institution being responsible for data stewardship, another for community engagement, and another for strategic governance. In some cases, the governance structure was composed of all organizations that contribute data.	141.pdf (Humanitarian Open Street Map): The commons is governed and operated by three organizations: The Humanitarian OpenStreetMap Team, the Heidelberg Institute for Geoinformation Technology, and the Humanitarian Data Exchange. Decisions are made by team members from all three organizations and informed by community/user feedback and consultations.

Operational Management Entities		
Structure	**Details**	**Examples**
In-House Day to Day Technical Management	(96/146) Around 65% of submissions indicated that day-to-day technical management would be handled in-house (i.e., by the organization submitting the proposal), either entirely or partially, with some external support. Some of these proposals did not clearly indicate who would manage the technical infrastructure and operations of the commons, but generally implied that it would be handled in-house.	124.pdf (Refugee Data Hub): Day-to-day operations are managed by the proposing group, The Hive at USA for UNHCR. A dedicated team of data scientists and platform developers will maintain the commons and implement the strategic decisions by the governing body, a multi-stakeholder board.
Technical Partner or Host Institution	Some submissions indicated that they would partner with a digital infrastructure provider or a host	100.pdf (Know Your City Academy): In this proposal, an outside technical partner,

	institution to support the development of a platform for the commons.	Arkology Studio, provides the data commons infrastructure, documentation, and tools. The proposing organization, Slum Dwellers International, maintains data ethics, validation, performance evaluation, and community participation/stewardship.
Other	In a handful of submissions, the proposing entity was a software startup. Some indicated that they would create a team of individuals and technology developers from a range of organizational affiliations, or use volunteer contributions.	91.pdf (Querido Diário): Described dozens of volunteer developers, maintainers

Ethics and Advisory Mechanisms		
Structure	**Details**	**Examples**
Advisory Panels or Councils	Around 52% of submissions included one or several advisory councils or working groups outside of a decision-making role. These groups of experts or community members can provide input on a variety of areas (i.e. feasibility, mission-alignment, legal expertise). For proposals where an internal team makes strategic decisions, an advisory council can provide crucial input and oversight. In other cases, an advisory panel supplements a multi-stakeholder governance board.	88.pdf (Zimbabwe Legal Intelligence Commons): In addition to a multi-stakeholder governing board, this proposal describes two advisory entities. A Community Advisory Council consisting of community leaders, advocates, and end users is responsible for delivering feedback and evaluating the accessibility and relevance of the commons. A Content Governance Panel, made up of subject-specific experts, faculty, and language specialists, verifies the accuracy of the content in the commons and any translations present.
Ethics Review Councils	About 20% of proposals indicated a designated ethics review council or group. This can	145.pdf (The Global Freedom of Information Data Commons): This proposal describes an

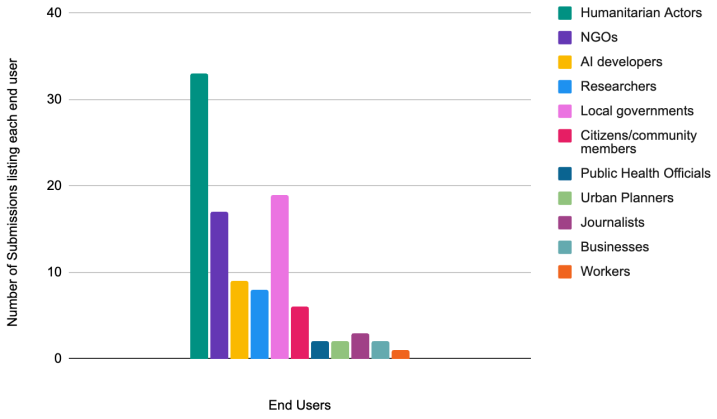
	sometimes overlap with either an advisory council or technical advisory council. Some proposals had designated councils for doing routine ethics audits and/or reviewing flagged ethical issues.	ethics panel of human rights advocates and community representatives that will address sensitive decisions about data inclusion, privacy protection, and analysis methodology.
Technical Advisory Councils	Some proposals outlined a technical advisory council in addition to the day-to-day technical team. A technical advisory council, usually composed of tech and data experts, can provide insight into data cybersecurity, interoperability, alignment with data standards, and AI implementation.	94.pdf (Education Data Commons): A technical advisory committee advises on data standards and interoperability, privacy, cybersecurity, and the ethics and accuracy of AI tools. This is in addition to the internal team that manages technical infrastructure.
Institutional Oversight	Occasionally, proposals indicated that a certain institution would play an advisory role. The specifics depend heavily on the nature of the data commons and the rest of the governance structure.	164.pdf (Nigeria Nutrition Data Commons): The National Health Research Ethics Committee, a national regulatory body, will conduct data privacy impact assessments.

Community Feedback and Participation		
Testing & Ideation Groups	This could include community-centered participative design workshops or pilot testing with end users.	109.pdf (GANNET Situation Hub Data Commons): This proposal supplements their multi-stakeholder board with a separate testing and ideation group of users from humanitarian organizations. This group tests new features, provides structured feedback on functionality and content, and identifies needs and use cases.
Public Community Assemblies	Public community assemblies or town halls (often quarterly or annually) allow end users, data contributors, or community members to share concerns, feedback, questions, and usage.	107.pdf (CIVICommons): Contributors and users are invited to data assemblies to help interpret results, identify blind spots, and shape future priorities.

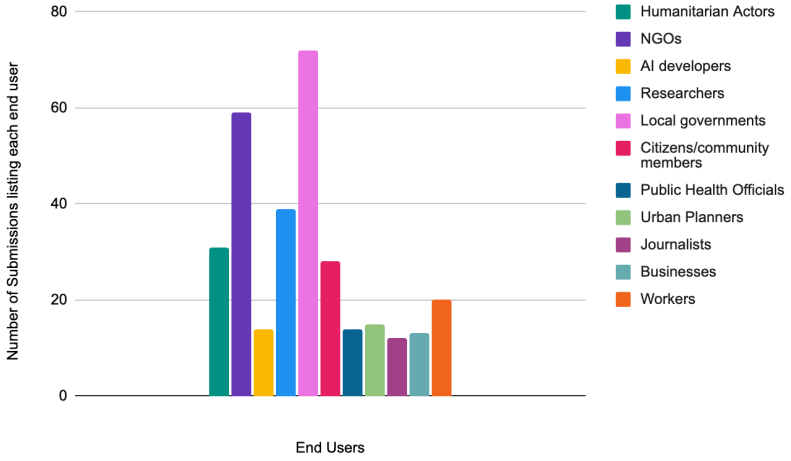
Community Trainings	Data literacy training, onboarding toolkits, training on new features or updates, training for community users or non-technical users, tutorials, etc	16.pdf (ClearGov Commons): Trainings for local actors to improve their data literacy and platform usage skills
Real-time Feedback Mechanisms	A variety: Feedback portal or form, a channel for reporting data errors or misuse, in-app flagging mechanisms (sometimes with a defined response system, such as triggering an independent ethics review or a 7-day response window), WhatsApp/SMS channels for feedback, collaborative platform for reviewing, correcting, and providing feedback on the AI model	71.pdf (Event Data Deeplomacy): Researchers can submit model improvements or propose new event taxonomies. Civic tech organizations can suggest interface enhancements. Local partners can flag gaps or contextual errors in the data. Submissions are reviewed through a peer-informed process and, if approved, are integrated into the commons with full attribution. 90.pdf (IQLand): Users will be able to submit: Comments on discrepancies between our output and local experience; requests for prioritizing updates in certain regions or jurisdictions. The feedback is reviewed by the internal team and can lead to corrections or trigger human review of edge cases.
Surveys	Annual surveys for users, often with results shared publicly to the community.	134.pdf (South Sudan Nexus): Scorecards and community perception surveys to measure trust over time
Audits and Reporting	Applicants described public dashboards, regular reports, and other transparency mechanisms. Public dashboards or reports can convey usage statistics, data contributors and users, the impact of different data sources, and the outcomes. Some emphasized data lineage trackers. Many also described publicly sharing governance decisions, voting logs, audit results, and future plans.	57.pdf (YouControl): Transparency Dashboard where users can track: What data is included and from where; when it was last updated; how it's used in the commons and by which groups. 170.pdf (ClimateCommons): Public-Dashboards showing where data is collected, how it is used, and what decisions it informs.

Extra End User Graphs by Focus Group

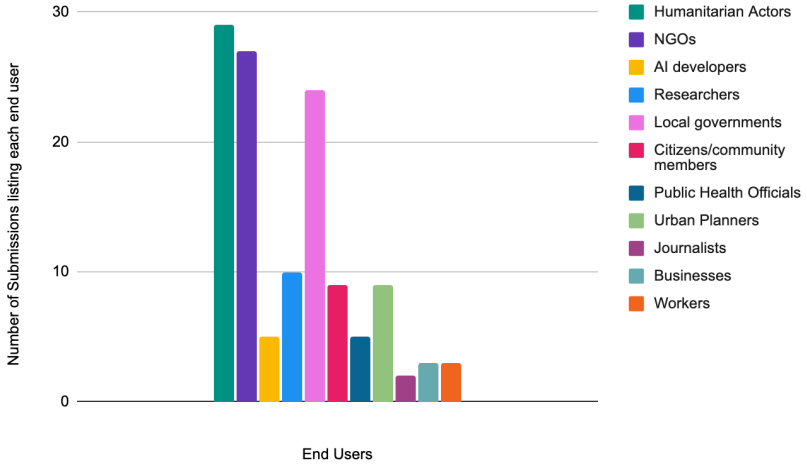
End Users Listed (Focus Area: Humanitarian Response)



End Users Listed (Focus Area: Localized Decision-Making)

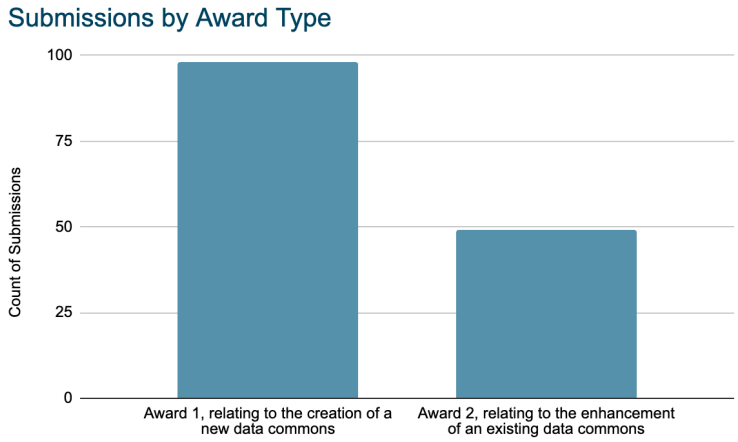


End Users Listed (Focus Area: Both)



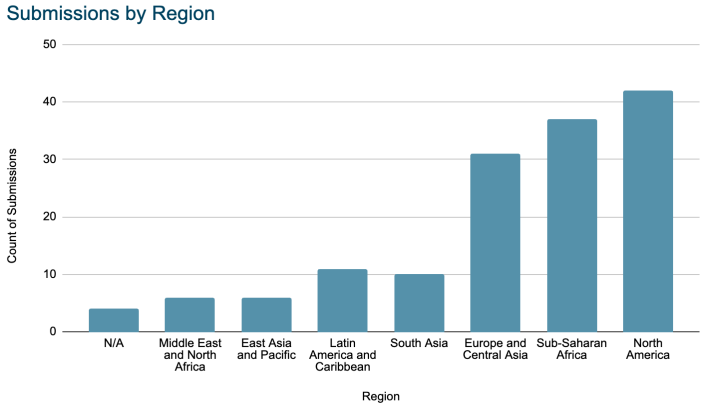
Past Analysis for Reference (updated for accuracy - identified and removed duplicates):

Award Type



Region

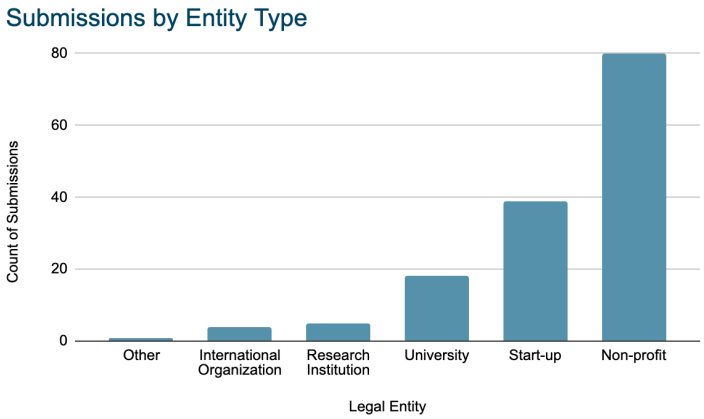
Region	Count of Submissions
Middle East and North Africa	6
East Asia and Pacific	6
Latin America and Caribbean	11
South Asia	10
Europe and Central Asia	31
Sub-Saharan Africa	37
North America	42
N/A	4
Total	**147**



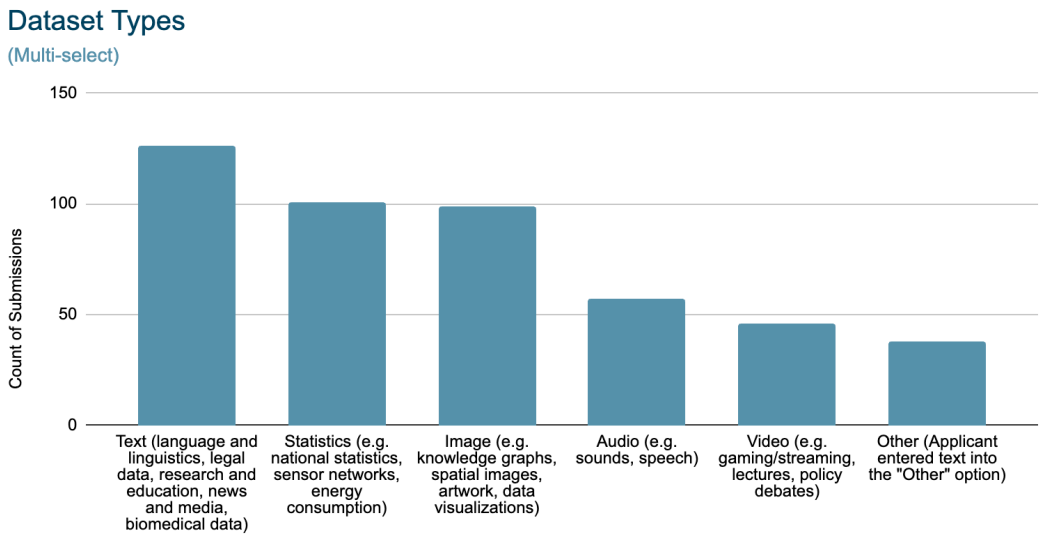
Global Map of Submissions

Entity Type

Legal Entity	Count of Submissions
Other	1
International Organization	4
Research Institution	5
University	18
Start-up	39
Non-profit	80
Total	**147**

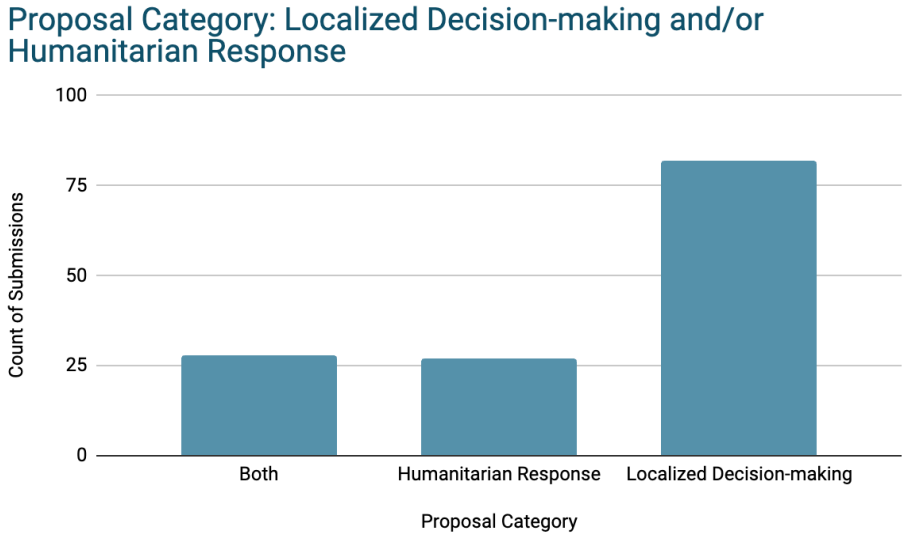


Dataset Type



Dataset Type (Muti-select)	Count of Submissions
Text (language and linguistics, legal data, research and education, news and media, biomedical data)	126
Statistics (e.g. national statistics, sensor networks, energy consumption)	101
Image (e.g. knowledge graphs, spatial images, artwork, data visualizations)	99
Audio (e.g. sounds, speech)	57
Video (e.g. gaming/streaming, lectures, policy debates)	46
Other (applicant-entered response)	38

Humanitarian Response and Local Decision Making



(Note: approximate, based on brief manual classification. Some proposals fell under neither category.)

Proposal Category	Count of Submissions
Local Decision Making (only)	82
Humanitarian Response (only)	27
Both	28

Top Proposal Topics

(Note: approximate, based on brief manual classification. Some proposals had more than one primary topic and therefore will be double counted below)

Proposal Topic	Count of Submissions
Climate/Environmental	27
Civic data (e.g. municipal plans, budgets, records)	14
Forced displacement	10
Water	6
Public Health/Healthcare	7
Energy/Clean Energy	5
Education	5
Food Insecurity/Nutrition	4
Urban Planning/Management	4

Country Breakdown

Submissions are from 51 countries.

Country Name	Count of Submissions
United States	40
Nigeria	15
United Kingdom	6
Netherlands	5
Brazil	4
India	4
South Africa	4
Colombia	3
France	3
Iran	3
Kenya	3
Switzerland	3
Ukraine	3
Canada	2
Democratic Republic of the Congo	2
Germany	2
Italy	2
Nepal	2
Pakistan	2
Rwanda	2
Uganda	2
Zimbabwe	2
Albania	1
Antigua and Barbuda	1
Argentina	1
Armenia	1
Australia	1
Bangladesh	1
Costa Rica	1
Denmark	1

Ghana	1
Indonesia	1
Lebanon	1
Malaysia	1
Mexico	1
Morocco	1
Mozambique	1
Norway	1
Qatar	1
Senegal	1
South Korea	1
South Sudan	1
Spain	1
Sri Lanka	1
Sweden	1
Taiwan	1
Thailand	1
The Gambia	1
Togo	1
Turkey	1
Zambia	1
N/A	4
Total	**147**